Submission Worksheet

Submission Data

Course: IT265-002-S2026
Assignment: IT265 Case Study - Personal Choice
Student: Kelsey C. (kc776)
Status: Submitted | **Worksheet Progress:** 100%
Potential Grade: 10.00/10.00 (100.00%)
Received Grade: 0.00/10.00 (0.00%)
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View Link: https://learn.ethereallab.app/assignment/v3/IT265-002-S2026/it265-case-study-personal-choice/view/kc776

Instructions

Step 1: Pick a game you plan to analyze

Step 2: Playtest your game choice (or review streamers playing the game)

Step 3: Analyze, research, and review your chosen game. Collect resources (website links, etc that you used during the exploration) include these with the responses in the related sections. Fill in the responses of the below prompts/checklist/etc.

Step 4: Export the PDF. Upload it to Github and upload the same PDF to Canvas.

Section #1: (1.25 pts.) Game Overview

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Historical Context and Game Description

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Game's title, developer, publisher, platform, and release date.
- Historical context of the game's release and its place in the industry.
- Game's genre and how it compares to similar games of the time.

Your Response:

Game title: Little Nightmares **Developer:** Tarsier Studios **Publisher:** Bandai Namco Entertainment **Platform:** Playstation 4, Xbox One, Nintendo Switch **Release Date:** April 28th, 2017

28th, 2017

Historal Conent: *Little Nightmares* released during a time when indie-style horror games were gaining popularity, especially those focused on atmosphere rather than combat. Unlike traditional horror games that relied on jumpscares or weapons, this game emphasized vulnerability, environmental storytelling, and pshycological horror. It stood out for it unique art direction and minimal dialogue, helping push forward the trend of narrative-driven indie horror experiences.

Genre and Comparison The game is a puzzle platformer horror. Compared to similar games at the time, it focuses more heavily on stealth and tension rather than just puzzles. While games like *Limbo* and *Inside* emphasized physics based puzzles, *Little Nightmares* added stronger horror elements and character driven storytelling, making it mroe immersive and emotionally engaging!

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Gameplay Mechanics

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Discuss the core gameplay mechanics and how they shape the player's experience.
- Explain how players control the game and interact with it.
- Identify and describe any unique aspects or creative elements in the game's gameplay.

Your Response:

Core Gameplay Mechanics:

- Platforming (jumping, climbing, balancing)
- Stealth (avoid enemies rather than fighting - get caught = death)
- Puzzle solving (uses environment to progress)
- Resource interaction (moving objects, using keys, activating switches) The characters were so small compared to enemies who were dramatically larger. These mechanics shaped the experience by making the player feel small, vulnerable, and constantly at risk.

Player Control and Interaction Players control a small player, Six is her name, in a 2.5D environment using movement, jumping, grabbing, and crouching. Interaction is pretty limited but intentional. Players must carefully time actions, hide from enemies, and manipulate the environmentto survive. The lack of combat forces players to rely on strategy and awareness instead of aggression.

Unique/Creative Elements

- No dialogue storytelling: The story is told through visuals and environment rather than words.

- Scale and perception: The world is OVERSIZED, making the player feel small and powerless.
- Horror through mechanics: Instead of jumpscares, fear comes from slow tension, enemy design, and sound.
- Ambiguous narrative: Players must interpret the story for themselves, which encourages discussion and replayability. Check out the reddit forums for this game, it gets intense!!

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Section #2: (1.25 pts.) Software Architecture And Technology

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Technical Framework

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the game engine and any special software (middleware) used to make the game. Explain why these were important for making the game work.
- List the programming languages and software tools used to build the game. Discuss how these tools helped in creating the game's features.

Your Response:

Little Nightmares was developed using the Unreal Engine, which aided the games detailed environment and atmospheric lighting. The engine allowed the developers to build a visually rich world with dynamic shadows and realistic textures, which are crucial for a horror experience that relies on tension rather than combat. Middleware tools for physics and animation also helped create smooth character movement and realistic object interactions, such as pushing and climbing structures. The game was primarily developed using C++ and Blueprint scripting within Unreal Engine. These tools allowed developers to efficiently build gameplay systems, enemy behaviors, and environmental interactions. Unreal's visual scripting (Blueprint) made it easier to design puzzles and trigger events without needing to hard-code everything, which helped the team focus more on creativity and level design. Overall, these tools supported the game's goal of creating a cinematic, immersive horror experience.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Innovations and Challenges

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Identify and describe any new or unique technical features in the game. Explain how these features made the game different or improved it.
- Discuss any major difficulties the developers encountered while making the game. Describe how they solved these problems.

Your Response:

One of the most unqiue technical features of *Little Nightmares* is its 2.5D design, where players move in a side-scrolling format while experiencing fully 3D environments. This allowed for cinematic camera angels and a strong sense of depth, making the world feel larger and intimidating. Another innovation is how the game uses environmental storytelling and AI behavior instead of dialogue, relying on visual cues and enemy movement patterns to guide the player. As I was researching, I read that a major challenge for the developers was balancing camera perspective and player control. Being that the game uses a fixed camera in a 3D space, it could make move and depth perception very difficult. To solve this, the developers carefully designed levels and camera angles to subtly guide players and reduce confusion. The also had to balance difficulty so that the game felt tense but not unfair, which they acheived through playtesting and refining enemy behavior and puzzle design.

IMO: I noticed while playing that the developers subtly put pieces of rubbish as indicators of where I should jump from because the angles made it too hard to know if I'm actually facing the rope or object that I need to grab on to. It was only after playing several times that I realized this so I appreciate them not making the answers so obvious sometimes.

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Section #3: (1.25 pts.) Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Mechanics Analysis

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Explore and describe the main rules and actions that players use in the game. Explain how these core mechanics define the game's playstyle.
- Discuss how the game's core mechanics keep players interested and involved. Describe the ways these mechanics make the game fun or challenging.

Your Response:

The core mechanics of *Little Nightmares* includes platforming, stealth, and puzzle-

solving. Players must run, jump, climb, and hide while avoiding enemies rather than fighting them. These mechanics define the game's playstyle by making the player feel small, vulnerable, and constantly in danger. These mechanics keep players engaged by creating constant tension and problem solving movements. For example, players must carefully time movements, observe enemy patterns, and interact with the environment to progress. The lack of combat forces players to think strategically. which makes every success feel rewarding...believe me. This combination of fear, curiosity, and challenge is what makes this game fun and memorable.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Level Design

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the design of the game's levels or environments. Focus on the layout, obstacles, and visual elements, and how they contribute to the game's setting.
- Explain how the level or environment design affects the way players play the game. Discuss how these design choices impact the overall experience, such as creating challenges, guiding the player, or setting the mood.

Your Response:

The level design in *Little Nightmares* is (in my opinion) one of its strongest features. Each area is carefully crafters with tight corridors, large open rooms, and interactive objects that create both puzzles and obstacles. The environments are visually dark and distorted, reinforcingthe unsettling atmosphere of the game's world. The design of these levels directly affects how players approach the game. Players are often guided subtly through lighting, sound, and environmental clues rather than explicit instructions. This creates a sense of exploration and discovery while still maintaining direction. The level design also builds tension by controlling pacing, slow, quiet sections are often followed by intense chase sequences, keeping players emotionally invested.

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Section #4: (1.25 pts.) Graphic And Audio Design

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Graphic and Audio Design

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the game's visual appearance and the artistic choices made. Discuss elements like color, art style, and thematic consistency, and how they contribute to the game's overall look and feel.
- Discuss the design of the game's characters and environments. Focus on aspects such as realism, creativity, and how they fit within the game's world. Explain how these designs enhance the player's immersion in the game.

Your Response:

The visual design of *Little Nightmares* is incredible. Truly, it is, the game uses a dark, muted color palette with occasional bright contrast, like Six's yellow raincoat, which helps guide the player's focus while maintaining a creepy atmosphere. IThe art style is stylized rather than realistic, with exaggerated proportions that make adults appear monstrous and overwhelming. The characted and environment desigs are both creative and symbolic. The oversized world makes you feel powerless, while the grotesque enemy design reflects a distorted view of adulthood, I'm tying in my interpretation, but this game represents how children, especially orphaned or vulnerable ones might perceive the adult world as frightening and unfair. Although it may not be this, I love that the design choices of this game allows players to interpret the story in their own way which enhances immersion and emotional impact.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Audio Design

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Examine the game's sound design, focusing on the music and sound effects. Describe how they are used and their quality. Discuss any memorable or unique audio elements in the game.
- Explain how the game's audio contributes to its overall mood and setting. Discuss how sound and music influence the player's emotional response and enhance the gaming experience.

Your Response:

sThe sound design in *Little Nightmares* is subtle but super effective. Instead of relying on loud jump scares, the game uses ambient sounds, background noise, and minimal music to build tension. Sounds like your heart pacing faster and slower, creaking floors, distant footsteps, and breathing create a constant feeling of unease. The audio plays a major role in shaping the plays emotional experience. Quiet moments make players feel anxious, while sudden sounds increase tension during chase scenes. The lack of diaglogue also makes sound even more important, as it helps tell the story and guide the player. Overall, the audio design enhances the user experience and horror by making the world feel unpredictable.

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Section #5: (1.25 pts.) User Interface And User Experience

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - User Interface and User Experience

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the layout of the game's user interface (UI) and how it functions. Discuss elements like menus, icons, and on-screen prompts, and how they help players navigate and understand the game.
- Evaluate how well the game's UI communicates important information to players. Discuss aspects such as clarity, readability, and the ability of the UI to provide necessary game details without overwhelming or confusing the player.

Your Response:

The user interface in *Little Nightmares* is extremely minimal. There are no cluttered HUD elements; instead, the game relies on simple prompts and visual cues to guide the player. Menus are clean and easy to navigate allowing players to focus on the experience rather than distractions. The UI communicates information effectively without overwhelming the player. Because the game avoids excessive text or instructions, players learn through interaction and observation. This design choice supports the game's mysterious tone and encourages exploration.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - UX Analysis

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Discuss the overall feel of playing the game, focusing on how different aspects of the game contribute to the player's experience. Analyze how these elements, such as ease of use, game flow, and feedback, affect the gameplay.
- Evaluate the design decisions made to enhance the player's experience. Consider factors like tutorial design, learning curve, and player engagement. Discuss how effective these choices are in making the game enjoyable and accessible to players.

Your Response:

The overall experience of playing *Little Nightmares* feels extremely immersive, tense, yet rewarding. The game has a smooth flow, mechanics are introduced in a way that doesn't overwhelm players. The learning curve is natural, players figure things out through gameplay rather than tutorials. The design choices strongly enhance engagement. The lackc of hand holding encourages curiosity, while the atmosphere keeps players emotionally invested. This makes the game super appealing for people like myself who love horror games but gets overwhelmed easily. I would consider this a great horror game to play and work your way up the horror game ladder.

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Section #6: (1.25 pts.) Narrative And Storytelling

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Narrative Structure

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the game's story, including its narrative structure, main plot points, and the setting in which it takes place. Discuss how these elements come together to create a cohesive and engaging story.
- Analyze the storytelling techniques used in the game, such as dialogue, cutscenes, or environmental storytelling. Evaluate how effectively these techniques convey the story and engage the player.

Your Response:

The story of *Little Nightmares* is intentionally ambiguous and told through environmental storytelling rather than dialogue. Players follow Six, a small girl navigating a disturbing world filled with grotesque adults. The plot unfolds through visual details, character encounters, and symbolic imagery rather than clear explanations.

A recurring element in the story is Six's unexplained hunger, which appears throughout the game and adds to the mystery of her character. This detail has led many players to interpret the story as a metaphor for childhood fear, trauma, or how children perceive the adult world. Others view it as a commentary on consumption, control, or survival. This open-ended storytelling is very effective because it encourages players to form their own interpretations and discuss theories.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Character and Integration

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Discuss the development of the game's characters. Describe their roles within the story, their personalities, and how they evolve throughout the game. Consider how the characters contribute to the overall narrative.
- Examine how the game's narrative and characters are integrated into the gameplay. Discuss how story elements are woven into the game mechanics and how this integration affects the player's experience.

Your Response:

Six is the main character in this series, and although she doesn't speak, her actions and design make her memorable. Her small size and vulerability contrast heavily with the massive, distorted enemies she encounters. Elements like her recurring hunger add complexity to her character, hinting deeper themes without explicitly explaining them. The narrative is deeply integrated into gameplay. Players experience the story through exploration, puzzles, and encounters rather than cutscenes. This makes the experience feel more personal and immersive, as players are actively participating in the story rather than just watching it unfold.

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Section #7: (1.25 pts.) Impact And Reception

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Reception and Impact

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Research and summarize how the game was received by critics and players. Include key reviews, ratings, and player feedback. Discuss any notable praise or criticism the game received.
- Analyze the game's impact on the gaming industry. Discuss how it may have influenced game design, trends, or inspired other games. Consider any lasting effects it has had on the industry.

Your Response:

Little Nightmares was widely praised by both critics and players for its atmosphere, art style, and storytelling. Many reviews highlighted it unique approach to horror, focusing on tension and visuals rather than combat. Some criticism included its short length and occasional control issues, but overall reception was positive. The game

had a strong impact on the horror genre by reinforcing the value of environmental storytelling and minimalist design. It also helped inpire similar indie horror games that focus on atmosphere and narrative rather than action.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Cultural Significance

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Examine the game's cultural significance and the legacy it has left behind. Discuss how the game has been remembered over time and its status in the gaming community.
- Describe the game's presence and representation in media, such as films, books, or online content. Discuss its role in fan communities and any influence it has had on broader cultural aspects, such as art, music, or social trends.

Your Response:

Over time, *Little Nightmares* has developed a strong fan community, including myself. Players continue to create theories, fan art, and discussions about the game's meaning and symbolism. Its unique style and storytelling have made it memorable within the gaming community. The games presence online, through YouTube theories, gameplay videos, and discussions, has helped maintain relevance. Its influence can be seen in other games that prioritize atmosphere, mystery, and emotional storytelling.

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Section #8: (1.25 pts.) Reflection

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Describe your personal experience playing the chosen game

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Was it "fun"? What made it fun or not fun?
- Is this genre/game-type aligned with personal interests?
- What made you pick this game? Was it a good choice?

Your Response:

I really enjoyed playing Little Nightmares and found it both fun and memorable. What

I really enjoyed playing Little Nightmares and found it both fun and memorable. What made it fun was the combination of exploration, puzzle-solving, and the constant tension from avoiding enemies.This genre aligns with my interests because I enjoy games that focus more on atmosphere and storytelling rather than combat. I chose this game because I love the series, and it turned out to be a great choice because it offers a unique and meaningful experience.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Assignment Reflection

Progress: 100%

Details:

- What interesting or new "thing(s)" did you learn during your research and analysis?
- Did you find it was easy to come across the information you were looking for? What was your primary means of research/analysis?

Your Response:

One interesting thing I learned is how much of the game's story is told without dialogue, relying entirely on visuals and environment. It made me realize how powerful environmental storytelling can be in game design. It was relatively easy to find information, especially through reviews and player discussions, since many people have shared their interpretations of the game. Watching gameplay and reading theories helped deepen my understanding of the story and design choices.

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